THE BLACKHEARTS

Blood, Coin, and Betrayal

A Grimdark Campaign of Crime, Ambition, and Survival

"There are no heroes here. Only those who survive long enough to become villains."

Between the eastern reaches of Chalmouth, the ancient dwarven halls of Dun Karthik to the south, and the western dominion of Kelvothis lies a vast, brooding wilderness known as the Gloombough.

It is a place of towering blackwoods, forgotten trails, mist-choked hollows, and ruins swallowed by centuries of creeping vegetation. The roads that skirt its borders are traveled by merchants, pilgrims, soldiers, and nobles. Some arrive at their destinations. Others are never seen again.

The Gloombough belongs to no king.

No army patrols its depths. No magistrate dispenses justice beneath its ancient canopy. Here, the law is whatever a man can enforce with steel, cunning, or cruelty.

And somewhere within that sprawling wilderness, hidden from the eyes of civilized men, lies the stronghold of a notorious brotherhood of thieves, brigands, cutthroats, and mercenaries.

They are known as the Blackhearts.

Their name is whispered in roadside taverns, cursed by merchants, and spoken with dread by those unfortunate enough to have crossed their path. For years, the Blackhearts have preyed upon the borderlands, growing wealthy through robbery, extortion, kidnapping, smuggling, and murder.

They serve no crown, swear allegiance to no lord, and recognize no authority beyond their own.

And you have come to join them.

Perhaps you are a deserter fleeing the gallows. A murderer seeking sanctuary. A common thief with ambitions beyond picking pockets. A sellsword whose conscience has finally become too expensive. Or simply a desperate soul who has discovered that honest labor

pays poorly, while dishonesty can make a man rich.

Your reasons matter little.

Your usefulness matters greatly.

You begin as initiates of the Blackhearts, the lowest creatures in a hierarchy built upon violence, greed, loyalty, and fear. You possess no reputation, no influence, and no guarantee of survival. The veterans regard you with contempt. The guildmasters see you as expendable. Even your fellow initiates may someday sell you for a handful of silver.

But there is opportunity here.

Caravans laden with foreign treasure travel the lonely roads. Wealthy merchants sleep behind locked doors, believing themselves secure. Noble families harbor secrets worth fortunes. Rival brigands encroach upon Blackheart territory. And throughout the borderlands, there are men willing to pay handsomely for deeds they dare not perform themselves.

Robbery. Extortion. Kidnapping. Smuggling. Poisoning. Assassination.

No contract is too dishonorable. No victim too important. No betrayal beyond consideration.

Yet gold is only half the game.

Within the Blackhearts, alliances are forged in alehouses and broken in dark corridors. Ambitious lieutenants scheme against their superiors. Informants whisper to distant authorities. Rival factions compete for lucrative contracts, influence, and control. A clever initiate might rise through the ranks, command hardened killers, establish a criminal empire, or even seize leadership of the Blackhearts themselves.

A foolish one may end up hanging from a roadside gibbet, his corpse left for the crows.

And beyond the petty ambitions of men, older things endure.

Magic is scarce in these lands, and those who wield it are feared for good reason. Sorcery is not the common trickery of traveling entertainers. It is a dreadful power, capable of twisting flesh, shattering minds, and condemning entire bloodlines. Ancient places lie undisturbed beneath the Gloombough, and some treasures are buried not to protect them from thieves, but to protect the living from what lies within.

You will not be chosen by prophecy.

You will not be entrusted with saving the kingdom.

There is no righteous cause awaiting your sword.

There are only the Blackhearts, the next contract, and the weight of coin in your purse.

What you become is entirely your affair.

A feared highwayman. A master burglar. A ruthless enforcer. A wealthy crime lord. A traitor. A corpse.

In the Gloombough, reputations are written in blood, fortunes are built upon the misfortune of others, and loyalty lasts precisely as long as it remains profitable.

The Blackhearts are recruiting.

The roads are rich.

And the dead have no use for silver.

Welcome to the Blackhearts.